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CROSSING CULTURES: STUDENT TRAVEL AND PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT

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ABSTRACT. *This paper is concerned with what students do and learn when they travel abroad. First, the behavior and daily routines of American college students travelling in Europe, while on a term abroad, are examined through their journals and travel logs and the researcher's observations. What the students learn about other cultures is often superficial, yet the experience is found to be educational in ways that were unexpected. Much of the personal benefit of travel comes not from what students learn about the places or cultures they visit, but from the need to continuously make decisions and deal with the demands of daily life in new and unfamiliar settings. It is suggested that these experiences foster personal development in several ways.* © *1997 Published by Elsevier Science Ltd. All rights reserved.*

In a landmark study of American students in Europe, Jerry Carlson et al. (1990) found that one of the most valuable activities that students engage in while abroad is travel. American students do a lot of it. The 400 students from four universities in the Carlson study spent an average of thirty days on the road during their academic year abroad (Carlson et al., 1990, p. 11). It is commonplace for students on terms abroad in Europe to spend weekends and vacations travelling. Some terms abroad do not schedule classes on Fridays so that students can have longer weekends to devote to travel.

What do students actually do when they travel? And is it educationally enriching? I spoke with a half dozen directors of university study abroad programs all of whom were of the opinion that travelling is an important part of the students' overseas experience. Yet few could say exactly why it is educational. A search through the literature was of little help. Many

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studies (e.g., Klineberg & Hull, 1979; Lambert, 1989; Kauffmann et al., 1992) have examined the foreign study experience, but none, to my knowledge, have looked specifically at student travel or its impacts on students.

The first half of this paper describes the travel and daily routines of a group of American students studying in Innsbruck, Austria in the summer of 1993 on a University of New Orleans program. The second half of the paper explores how, despite the superficial nature of student wanderings across Europe, their travel is educational and contributes to personal growth. Finally, I attempt to explain what it is about the travel environment that produces these positive outcomes.

Some discussion of my background and why I did this research is in order, especially since I did not go to Austria with the intention of doing this study. Although most of the research on the impact of foreign study has been done by educational psychologists, I am a cultural anthropologist. I have been taking students abroad, however, for over fifteen years on anthropology field programs to Barbados and Ireland, and I have also taught a regular term abroad in Japan.

In 1993, I was invited to teach in a foreign study program at the University of Innsbruck. The program, organized by the University of New Orleans, takes 225 American university students to Austria each summer for six weeks. The students attend class four days a week and then—using Eurail passes which provide them with unlimited train travel for a single price—travel during the three-day weekends.

In Innsbruck, an anthropologist colleague and I required our students to keep a daily journal about their experiences.[1] At midterm, when I collected and began reading my students' journals I was startled at how shallow their engagement with the people and places they visited seemed to be. Assuming that their travel would be an immensely enriching experience, I had made the journals an important part of the course. Yet there was little evidence that they had learned much about any European culture; their observations on the whole seemed naive and simplistic. Nevertheless, there was plenty of evidence, both in the journals and from discussions in class, that their time spent travelling had not been wasted, that it was important in ways that neither I nor my colleagues had anticipated. In fact, the students believed they learned more from their travels than they did from their academic courses. It was not easy to accept the notion that my efforts in the classroom meant less to them than their random, often chaotic, weekend sojourns, but the idea piqued my curiosity about what was happening to them on their trips and why they regarded it as so

[1]The students were asked to divide their journal into chapters, each dealing with a different broad topic, including customs, food, people, language, stories, etc. It was suggested that the students try to write in several different chapters each day in order to encourage them to observe and write about a range of experiences.

edifying. That is the central issue of this paper, but I am also concerned with describing in ethnographic terms what students do when they travel.

METHODS

Data were gathered in a variety of ways. The journals of fifty-one students enrolled in three anthropology classes taught by me and Sharon Gmelch were the major source of information.[2] Detailed information on the students' activities and movements when they travelled were obtained through "travel logs" in which the students in one class recorded what they were doing and who they were with at regular intervals during their travel.[3] The use of the travel log, like the journals, was fortuitous since I assigned them merely to help the students see and make sense of the patterns in their travelling. At the end of the term a twenty item open-ended questionnaire was used in all three classes to gather additional data about their experiences. Insight into the students' experiences also came from many informal conversations with students in and outside of the classroom, and especially during afternoon hikes. In fact, hiking proved to be an ideal setting for talking casually with students about a broad range of subjects. I also spent one weekend duplicating the activities and movements that my students had reported for a trip to Salzburg, in order to get a sense of what they were seeing and doing.

STUDENT TRAVEL AND TOURISM

At the end of classes each Thursday afternoon, the students, packs on their backs, set out for their weekend sojourn. With Eurail passes, they travelled throughout Western Europe and parts of Central Europe. They went wherever the trains would conveniently take them, but their primary destinations were the places other students had recommended, which also happened to be the places featured in the guide books the students read, notably *Let's Go Europe*. The most popular destinations were Venice,

[2]Some psychologists (Biggs, 1992a; Cloninger pers. comm.) assert that journals are a particularly effective means of understanding personal growth in students. Writing about students in cross-cultural situations, Donald Biggs argues that students think about and describe their study abroad experiences with "narrative forms of thought" and not with a logical, abstract and/or context independent mode of thought Biggs (1992b, p. 7). It is primarily narrative accounts of their experiences that students write in journals. Hence, journals are a conduit to understanding the development of the students' narrative thinking (these narratives or stories about life events influence and guide behavior).

[3]The students recorded, from the time they got up in the morning until they retired at night, what they did—each activity, number of companions involved, and its duration. Each student then calculated, at the end of the weekend, how much time had been spent in each type of activity (e.g., waiting for trains, riding trains, walking around, shopping, eating, etc).

Florence, and Rome in Italy; Vienna and Salzburg in Austria; Munich and Berlin in Germany; Budapest, Hungary; and Prague, Czechoslovakia. They also went to resort areas on the Italian and French Riviera, and to Interlaken in the Swiss Alps, a center of adventure tourism.

The students travelled frequently and never stayed long in one place. Data obtained from their travel logs show that they visited an average of 1.72 countries and 2.4 cities per weekend.[4] This means that the average student spent just slightly over one day in each of the cities he or she visited. It was primarily the resort areas of the French or Italian Riviera (beaches) and Interlaken, Switzerland (mountains and adventure tourism) where they stayed longer. Their city-a-day approach to travel was due to several factors. Many wanted to see as much of Europe as they could during their brief time abroad because they were not sure when, if ever, they would come back. As one student said, expressing the sentiments of many, "I wanted to be able to go home and say that I saw as much as I could in the six weeks that I was here." There was also some competition among students, especially males, to see how much of Europe they could see with their Eurail passes. For many students, getting to know the places they visited mattered far less than being able to say that they had been there.

The tendency to "map hop," as some of the students referred to it, was also motivated by their desire to get maximum value from their Eurail passes, for which they each had paid about $500. They travelled hastily despite their professors' and the program director's advice "not to run up the mileage," but to get to know the places they visited. One consequence of their highly mobile form of tourism was that they spent a lot of time waiting in train stations and sitting on trains. Over an average three-day or 72-hour weekend, the students spent 18.7 hours on trains and 3.0 hours in stations waiting for them. That is, nearly one-third of their time was spent in transit. Students sometimes travelled at night, however, in order to save the cost of accommodation and to leave their days free to sightsee. But travelling at night often meant that they had not gotten adequate sleep and returned to campus exhausted.

The importance of the trains in the students' lives could be seen in the articles published in the university program's weekly newspaper. In one issue, for example, there was a poem about riding trains at night, an editorial on how to deal with train conductors who demand payment when a Eurail pass is improperly filled out, and a satire entitled "Top Ten Bad Ideas in East Central Europe," in which five of the bad ideas had to do with trains.

Despite all the time spent in transit, the journey itself was much less

[4]Over the six week term the students travelled in an average of 5.5 countries. Two students had gone to fourteen countries, while one middle-aged adult student never left Austria.

important to most students than the destination. Few reported or were observed to spend much time looking out the window. One student wrote about her traveling companions: "They want to run to the goal and run back; I want to enjoy the journey." Another student reflected:

> I seemed to be preoccupied on most train rides, if not sleeping, reading, or writing, just talking or laughing with friends. Now that I look back I wish that I had paid more attention to the places that we were passing through because I think that probably a lot more would have come out of it.

But there were an equal number of students who had no regrets. One female who calculated that she had spent five full days sitting on trains since arriving at Innsbruck, wrote:

> Some of my most striking moments occurred on the trains—the train strike in Milan, sleeping in couchettes with complete strangers, being hot as hell, the French man that molested Betsy and I, the beautiful scenery in Switzerland, random thoughts, open windows, mountains... sleeping with Andrew, not knowing what stop to get off.

Decisions about where to go next were often spontaneous, made with little planning. If students were disappointed with the place they had traveled to, they were inclined to return to the train station to choose a new destination. The choice of where to go was often determined by where the next available train was heading. If, for example, they were thinking of going to Florence but the wait for the train to Milan was half as long, they would be just as likely to go to Milan.

As the term progressed many students slowed down, staying longer in the places they visited. And as they did so, many became critical of those who still traveled excessively. One student, who had visited eight countries in her first three weekends in Innsbruck commented: "Americans approach their leisure activity like work... they exhaust themselves running about trying to get in as much as they can. I am guilty of this too, but I now try to spend some time pondering where I am." And another student wrote in her journal:

> I wonder if we really enjoy the museum and sights that we see. It seems that too often we are too concerned about where to go next, and how we will get there, and that we don't always appreciate where we are at the time.

At the end of the term the same student wrote:

> I need to go back and stay for a longer period of time in each place. Everywhere we went everyone would ask why we only stayed for one day. And now I am wondering the same thing. For most Americans it seems to be enough to visit a place, take a few pictures and say to their friends and relatives, "Been there, done that."

GROUP SIZE

Students were asked to record in their travel logs the number of companions they traveled with, both during the journey and once they arrived at their destination. The average group size during the journey was 5.2 students, shrinking to 4.6 students once they arrived at their destination. Why such large groups? For most students, this was their first time abroad, and they were understandably nervous about traveling alone or even in pairs; they found security in numbers. Over the summer, as the students learned their way around and became more confident, the size of the groups declined by a third. The decline in numbers occurred as the students became aware of the liabilities of looking for accommodation, going to restaurants, and visiting places in large groups. As one student wrote: "I've discovered that it is better to travel in small numbers! Not only is it a pain to appease a large crowd, but you have to listen to constant complaining..." Some students saw other problems with traveling in large groups; one woman wrote the following in her journal while on a train to Amsterdam:

> As I head for the city of 24 hour decadence I have realized that we create our own little culture here and that may not be entirely good. Don't get me wrong, I've had fun. But our student culture isolates us from absorbing and trying to fit in to the cultures that we are visiting. Even in Innsbruck we tend to go out in flocks, mostly to local bars at night and the same bars over and over again. And more often than not, the places we choose are tourist magnets where we don't have any chance of meeting people in the country we are in. I think it will be important for me to come back to Europe with just one or two people.

Other students noted that they often followed the "herd" rather than deciding for themselves how they really wanted to spend their time. For example, a freshman male wrote about companions following him during a trip to Munich. He was the only one in the group who had been there before: "I said let's go to the Hofbrauhaus and everybody followed. I felt like the Pied Piper." And about her stay in Cannes, a female student wrote: "We ended up at the Miss Cannes pageant and how I don't know. Sara and Charles were following the music and paid thirty francs to get in, so we all followed along."

The students walked around the cities in groups rather than singly or in pairs. Although the average group size of 4.3 was a bit smaller than the size of the groups they traveled on the trains with, it was still large enough to limit their contact with local people.[5] Touring in groups has several consequences.

[5]The difference between the average group sizes of students when traveling versus when staying in cities is due to some groups, upon arriving at their destination, splitting up into smaller groups to look for accommodation.

Students spend most of their time interacting with one another and less time observing their surroundings. Their conversations, even when standing before great European art, architecture or scenery, are often about people, places, and events back home rather than where they are at that moment. And local people are less inclined to start a conversation with a group of students than they would if they were alone or in a pair. Carlson and his colleagues (1990, p. 11) found that "the most important medium for personal experience in the host country was conversation with host nationals". Thus, by traveling in large groups, students lessen the educational potential of their trips. Many of my students eventually became aware of this themselves, but were still not ready to give up the security of being in a group, although some said that on their next trip abroad they hoped to travel with fewer companions. A student who spent most of the summer traveling with five or more companions wrote about her fifth weekend on the road when for a single day she was away from the group:

> I really enjoyed the Italian Riviera. It was only Jennifer and I, and we met a lot of different people. On the train ride back I was by myself and literally took in everything—the people I saw, how they acted, a baby on the train yelling, everyone annoyed at him and I was too until the baby made me think of my niece and I laughed. Women talking to a couple and kissing cheeks, a couple leaving one another on the train. They were kissing and it made me so sad that they were leaving each other that I cried. Looking out the window at the gorgeous Mediterranean sea and cliffs . . . Being by myself I had lots of emotions going on inside of me that I hadn't felt before.

But few students ever traveled alone, and those who did were invariably traveling to meet someone else—a friend, pen pal, or relative who was also in Europe. Being on their own usually made them anxious. Before going to London to visit a college friend, another female student wrote in her journal "I'm very excited and nervous. I'll be in Europe all by myself. I'll have to make all the decisions without having to consult anyone. This will be an experience of independence."

DAILY ROUTINES OF STUDENT TRAVELERS

What do students actually do once they have arrived at their destination? Most do what the students who preceded them had recommended. They also use their guidebooks and get advice from the local tourist office. In Salzburg, they walk around the old town, climb the hill to the castle, and take the Sound of Music tour; in Venice they go to St. Mark's Square, ride the canals in a gondola or vaparetto, and visit the glass shops; in Munich they look at paintings in the Alte Pinakethek or technology in the Deutsches Museum, visit the Englischer Garten, and spend an evening in the Hofbrauhaus drinking beer with other tourists; in Florence they go to the Uffizi and the

Academic museums (the latter mainly to see the David); and in Budapest they visit the castle district and the free museums, and because goods and services are cheaper there than anywhere else they visit in Europe, they eat well and the female students go to the spa for massages, pedicures, and facials. And so on.

Early in the term the students rushed to the great cities of Western Europe—notably, Paris, Munich, Venice, and Vienna—where they did cultural things such as visit museums, galleries, and look at great architecture. Toward the end of the term, the students' interests shifted to places with opportunities for recreation, notably the beach resorts of the Italian and French Riviera, and Interlaken, Switzerland which offered para-gliding, white water rafting, and horseback riding. Consequently, the number of museums visited declined from an average of over one per weekend during the first half of the term to just a third of that during the last half of the term. When I asked students about this in class, some said, with others nodding their heads or murmuring in agreement, that they had their fill of museums and churches. One female student during the fifth week of the term, while staying on the French Riviera, wrote: "Laying out seems to be the only incentive these days! Whatever happened to sightseeing?"

Besides going to the prescribed attractions, the students spent their days walking the streets, looking at buildings, stepping into churches to gaze at the art and stained glass windows, sitting on benches watching people go by, resting in parks, and talking amongst themselves. And like tourists everywhere, they took photographs: an average of 16 pictures per weekend. Many of their photographs are of themselves and their companions posed in the foreground of the places they visited. When I asked why a postcard wouldn't be as good, one student said: "A photograph is proof that you've been there. You took it and it's got you and your friends in it."

There was nothing remarkable about the students eating habits, except perhaps that an average of 1.5 times per weekend they went to American style or franchise restaurants (e.g., McDonalds, NY Bagels, Pizza Hut). Their interest in American franchise restaurants was strongest when they were in countries like Hungary, where none of the students spoke the language and waiters spoke little or no English, making it difficult to decipher the menu. In Budapest, a group of students took a thirty minute taxi ride across the city merely to find a NY Bagels restaurant. Food was one of the subjects students were required to write about in their journals and almost invariably it was women who wrote the most. They wrote not only about the different kinds of foods they saw, but often what dishes they ordered for dinner. Generally, women students were more willing and interested in trying new foods, male students were more inclined to write about European beer and how it differed from American beer than the food they ate.

Time was also spent shopping. Female students were more inclined to set aside time specifically to shop, but students of both sexes made a habit

of looking at the goods displayed in shop windows as they walked around the cities. For many women, however, shopping was an integral part of their traveling; most, looking for bargains, could say what the best buys were in each country or city they went to, such as leather and jewelry in Italy, and Hummel dolls in Germany. Many were looking for "bargains"—high quality goods at lower prices than were available at home. The students shopped not just for themselves but also to find presents to take home for parents and friends. They also hoped to purchase goods that would serve as mementos of the places they had visited. The amount of time students spent shopping declined over the term as they acquired the requisite presents for people at home and their funds ran low.

By late afternoon, students typically returned to their hotel or hostel to nap. Evenings, after going out to dinner, were spent drinking and fraternizing in bars. The travel logs showed that only 14% of the students routinely did something other than go to bars in the evening. The students typically stayed out until midnight or later, and often reported going to bed having drunk too much and being exhausted. One female student characterized her companions in her journal as "young students who come to Europe to spend their parents money by getting drunk in as many different cities as possible." Another wrote about a recurrent dream she had in which she broke down crying from exhaustion: "Sometimes I feel like I just need to stop everything and sleep for several days non-stop. It would probably help if we all just eased up on the drinking and eating poorly."

PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT

It should be evident from the descriptions above that the students may not learn as much about European cultures as their professors would hope. As I noted earlier, when reading my students' journals, I was surprised by the superficiality of their engagement in the culture, and how little meaningful contact they had with local people. A colleague who read my description of what the students did in a draft of this paper, suggested that "Europe was for the students a big shopping mall in which to hang out, not a place to challenge ones cultural categories." Perhaps. But there is much evidence that traveling and living in Europe for a summer did have a significant impact on the students. In the pages that follow I will first describe some individual changes reported by the students, and then suggest a cause of these changes.[6]

[6]Kauffmann et al. (1992, p. 99) discuss the reliability and validity of students self reports, notably the lack of uniformity in the students' responses and the difficulty of comparison between studies. For example, the meaning given to *self-reliance* by one researcher may be the same that other researchers refer to as *independence* or *autonomy*. Similarly, *self-esteem* in some studies means the same as *self-confidence* in others (Kauffmann et al., 1992, p. 99). But Kauffmann et al. (1992) and others note that other techniques for measuring personal development can also be problematic, and that for some areas self reports yield better data than standardized tests or questionnaires.

At the end of the semester, I asked my students to read their journals imagining they had been written by someone else and then try to describe how the author had changed, if at all, since arriving in Europe. During afternoon hikes, I also had the opportunity to question a number of students in some depth about their perceptions. Two broad areas of change emerged in most accounts. A large majority of the students believed their experiences—having gone abroad on their own and having traveled extensively through Europe without the supervision or support of parents or other adults—had given them more self-confidence. Some typical declarations were: "I now have the confidence that I can handle any situation I encounter, in some way, even if I am alone, unable to communicate easily and unsure of the culture," and "I've learned that I don't need any pretenses, that if I just be myself people will still like me." One student referred to her reacting to an incident that occurred in London as evidence of her growing self-confidence. She was in Trafalgar Square where she and her travel companions wanted a picture of themselves sitting on top of a large stone lion:

> I was wearing my navy silk shorts outfit and slippery sandals. I was having difficulty getting up on the lion when a young girl asked me if I would like some help. So here I am flailing about trying to get up on this lion with this girl pushing up on my butt. My silk shorts came totally up my butt and a crowd of people, also waiting to climb up on the lions are standing below, right beneath me. I was so embarrassed when I finally got up, but I was psyched... It was not only a physical victory, it was also a mental victory. I might finally be at the period where I can say "this is who I am, you can like me or not like me." Actually I am probably not at that point yet, but I am getting closer. I am not as paralyzed by my insecurities and fears as I was before this trip.

Many students also said they believed they had become more *adaptable*; they were now better able to cope with the surprises, the inevitable problems that arise when traveling, and not having the comforts they were accustomed to at home. The terms they used when they wrote and talked about this change in themselves included being able to "survive," "cope," and "deal" with unfamiliar situations and minor adversity. For example, one female student wrote:

> This trip has made me more laid back. I always tended to need things on time and just the way I like it at home or else I became quite agitated. I suppose that is just part of being American. When you learn that things don't always go your way, and that you simply have to go with the flow. Here [Europe] you have to adjust to the differences... Your train isn't always going to be on time; you may not want to go everywhere that your travel companions do; the locals may not speak English or be particularly thrilled to see you; and you will not get ice in your drink. I can deal with that now.

This same student wrote that when she first arrived in Europe she was

angry with the limited hours that stores were open, but five weeks later she wrote: "I have learned to accept them... I now even think its great that they close the stores on weekends, as it gives people time to spend with their families." These perceptions of personal change were echoed by the students' parents who I interviewed over the telephone. When I asked if they thought their son or daughter had changed while abroad, most talked about them seeming more "mature" and "independent." Typical of many, one mother said about her daughter: "She was just so self-assured when she got back." The phenomenon the students and their parents described are all part of the process of what developmental psychologists refer to as "personal development." That is, the "unfolding, growth, evolution, expansion and maturation of the individual self" (Kauffmann et al., 1992, p. 124). Personal development is distinguished from "cognitive development" which has more to do with the acquisition of knowledge (e.g., what students actually learn about European cultures and places while studying and traveling).

These findings are consistent with what is reported in the research literature on the impact of international study programs. One study of 1,260 American Field Service students, for example, found that, compared to a control group which did not go abroad, the AFS students appeared to become "less materialistic, more adaptable, more independent in their thinking, more aware of their home country and culture, and better able to communicate with others and to think critically" (Hansel, 1988, p. 87). While the AFS students spent an entire academic year abroad, a study by Stitsworth (1988) has shown that even a short stay with a home stay family can have a significant effect. Stitsworth, who administered the California Psychological Inventory to 154 student exchangees before and after their one month stay in Japan as well as to a comparison group who did not study abroad, found personality changes in three areas: the student exchangees after their experience abroad had less conventional attitudes, were more adaptable in their thinking (e.g., they showed more tolerance of uncertainty and ambiguity), and scored higher on measures of independence and autonomy. (Stitsworth also found that students who paid for most of their trip changed more than those who paid only a small proportion.) Studies by Carlson et al. (1990), Kauffmann et al. (1992), and others have reported similar results.[7]

[7]The research by Carlson and his colleagues (1990) which tested students from four universities before and after their year overseas, as well as a control group who stayed at home, found the student exchangees returned with more empathy for the viewpoints of other nations, enhanced intellectuality and work habits, and greater persistence. The authors concluded that the sojourning students, in general, "achieved a number of the goals of a liberal education in terms of personal and intellectual development" (Carlson et al., 1990, p. 114).

But what interested me was not just how the students had changed, but why? After eighteen years of taking students abroad, I already knew that cross-cultural experiences have a positive impact on individual development—in particular, they become more confident, self-reliant, and adaptable (see Gmelch, 1992). But I was not sure what exactly caused this change. As I noted in the introduction, an idea came to me while reading my students' journals. The journals suggested that from the time the students left the familiarity of their Innsbruck dorm at the beginning of every weekend trip, they were continuously confronted with problems to solve—where to go, how to get there, where to stay, where best to change money, where to find good but reasonably priced places to eat, what sights were worth seeing given limited time, what places or areas of the city were unsafe and to be avoided, what goods were worth buying and where, and so on. In order to make good decisions, and to satisfy their basic needs, they had to learn how the local "systems" worked. They had to learn something about the culture. To do this they had to communicate with host nationals, asking the right questions and understanding the responses. Often they had to do this in a foreign language. Even in situations where locals understand English, meanings may be quite different, forcing students to find new ways to explain themselves. One student, after traveling in Hungary and Czechoslovakia, said he had become so adept at nonverbal communication and mimicking that he could not wait to get home to play charades.

To travel safely and economically, the students had to become adept at gathering information, and of asking the same questions of several different people to assure its reliability. Not surprisingly, many of my students reported that their travels had given them more confidence in speaking with strangers, and confidence in gathering information. Traveling in a foreign country also required a certain level of organization. Students had to remember to bring and keep track of their passport, Eurail pass, student identification, and their money and Travelers cheques.

Traveling is rarely predictable, and I believe students learned much from having to cope with surprises and unexpected problems and predicaments—missing a train connection, getting lost, arriving in a town only to discover there is no available accommodation, and so on. A dozen of the Innsbruck students, for example, found themselves stranded in Italy by a train strike. They had to find a way to let the college administrators in Innsbruck know they were okay, learn something about the strike in order to assess how long it might last, and look for alternative transportation back to Austria. Here is a nineteen year old female student's description of the problems she and her companions encountered in a single journey across Budapest on public transportation:

> We took the Metro [subway] and trams which was [sic] even more frustrating than the bus system. Along the way, we almost lost Susan, Kelly got her sunglasses stuck in the Metro doors, Susan almost had her purse stolen, and some weirdo put his face in my hair. But we made it to the bagel shop [NY Bagels].

For adolescents travelling on their own in a strange culture, these are significant life experiences.

Because the students travel in so many different countries and move so frequently—almost a new city every day—the challenges are multiplied. They have to find and arrange for travel, shelter, food, local transportation, and decide how best to spend their free time, not once but several times every weekend. Such challenges, of course, are compounded when the travel takes them across national borders. When students travel from Austria to Czechoslovakia, Hungary, Italy, France, and Spain, they are not just crossing political boundaries but cultural and language barriers, and therefore new social systems, new customs, and new meanings, the basics of which they must learn in order to get by. In some countries, women students face the additional problem of dealing with unwanted sexual advances from local men.

Support for the idea that personal growth is promoted by students having to cope with change and solve problems can be found in the work of Chickering (1969), Bruggemann (1987), and Kauffmann et al. (1992). Kauffmann and his colleagues (whose work is influenced by the research of both Bruggemann (1987) and Piaget and Inhelder (1958) on the growth of logical thinking among adolescents) assert that individual change and maturation occurs in "periods of discontinuity, displacement, and disjunction." Put differently, individuals acquire new understanding about life, culture, and self when they deal with changes in their environment and circumstances. In a similar vein, Chickering (1969), in his synthesis of the wide-ranging empirical evidence on student development, argues that growth is not simply a process of maturational unfolding, but one which requires stimulation.

Conversely, it is also argued that comparatively little change occurs when students are in "situations of equilibrium." In the words of Bruggemann, "personal development is . . . about . . . interaction in which the person is evoked, assaulted, and impinged upon in formative and transformative ways." Bruggemann (1987, p. 9) and Piaget and Inhelder (1958) say that the discrepancy or disjunction that individuals experience causes them to modify their view of reality—their attempts to resolve the discrepancy between what they formerly knew and what they are now confronted with leads them to a new and more mature understanding. Educational psychologist Donald Biggs (1992b) arrived at a similar conclusion in his attempt to assess the costs and benefits of study abroad for Cypriot students. He uses the term "surprises" to refer to the discrepancies

between the students' home culture, and the host culture which they encounter abroad. It is their exposure to these discrepancies or "conditions of difference," that present the students with "surprises," "troubles," or enigmas which, in their attempts at resolution, become "potent influences" in their development (Biggs, 1992b, p. 5). Of course other factors inherent in studying abroad also contribute to students' personal development. Being in a new school environment, for example, requires them to develop new social relationships; and the lack of the usual forms of recreation, such as college fraternity parties, talking to friends on the telephone, and going to the movies, forces them to find new ways to entertain themselves.

CONCLUSION

First, let me review the major points. By looking at what one group of American students actually did when traveling abroad, I found that they toured in groups, moved frequently, never staying in any one place for more than a day or two, often made decisions about where to go next on the spur of the moment, and had little contact with the local people or culture. Their daily routines varied but usually involved travelling in groups to see the recognized tourist attractions, shopping, taking afternoon naps, and staying out late drinking in bars or pubs. Their travel routines did, however, change over time: they slowed down, becoming less mobile, moved about in slightly smaller groups, did less shopping, and became more interested in recreation rather than seeing famous sites. Despite their limited immersion in the cultures they visited, it was found that the students' travel contributed to their personal development. They became more confident, self-reliant, and adaptable. It was hypothesized that the primary cause of this change were the daily challenges students faced in having to function and satisfy their basic needs in an ever changing array of foreign places, each requiring a new set of cultural understandings, often in a foreign language.

Now we need to ask to what extent the cognitive and developmental outcomes of the cross-cultural travel described here also apply to the students' non-travel experiences while studying on a foreign university campus? Do students who do not travel much derive less benefit from their time abroad? In the context of the present study it is difficult to know. I can say with some certainty, however, that after their initial adjustment to being in Innsbruck was over, had my students not traveled, their learning outcomes would have been different. In Innsbruck, they lived in a university dormitory with fellow Americans. When they first arrived they had to adjust to a new university system, a new urban environment, and, in the residence halls, a new social constellation, all of which posed challenges similar to what they later experienced in their travels. But once they got to know their way around the town and university and had made friends,

their lives settled into predictable routines, with their activities—from scheduled classes to the bars they went to at night—being more or less the same from day to day. In this now familiar environment they encountered far fewer challenges, fewer problems to solve, fewer decisions to make, and fewer cultural differences to make sense of than they did while travelling. In fact, students considered Innsbruck to be their "home" and the university dorm as their sanctuary, the place they returned to every Sunday night to rest and recuperate before setting off on a new European adventure the following Thursday. The essential difference between traveling and campus living, I believe, is that the former exposes students to cultural variation and requires them to adapt to and function in a new environment almost daily. The differences in educational outcomes largely follow from this.

That students initiate the traveling and enter into these experiences of their own volition, rather than as part of organized field trips, I believe, increases the educational value. Because it was their decision to go to Florence or Munich or wherever, they take "ownership" of it, which means that when something goes wrong they have only themselves to blame because no one told them what to do or where to go. Likewise when things go right, they take full credit. In psychological terms the focus of control is internal when students travel on their own, and largely external when they are on a college-organized and adult-supervised excursion.

In trying to understand the educational impacts of foreign study, Beth Hansel (1988) looked at research on experiential learning for insight. Her comparison with experiential learning seems particularly apt for student cross-cultural travel. In experiential learning the motivation to learn comes from the situation itself. Similarly, what students learn about the people and places they visit when travelling is motivated largely by a need to know in order to get by—in order to satisfy their basic needs as economically as possible while ensuring their safety and making good use of their time. Experiential learning, like student travel, offers intrinsic rewards and is not something that is done to satisfy a requirement, complete an assignment, or pass a course. In both experiential learning and cross-cultural travel, students apply the information they learn to daily life, and thereby promptly discover the gaps, deficiencies, and mistakes in their understandings (Hansel, 1988, p. 179). Students use more of their senses to gain information, rather than depending solely on language and abstract symbols as they do in conventional classroom instruction. Finally, learning in both settings is holistic so that relationships are better grasped than when each part is studied separately.

Perhaps one lesson that can be learned from this research is the importance of encouraging and enabling students to travel on their own. University sponsored and organized study trips are not a substitute for independent travel. Secondly, students should be encouraged to travel in small numbers as it increases their likelihood of interacting with local

people. Smaller groups would also mean that individual students would have to cope with the challenges of getting information and solving daily problems more directly, with less diffusion of responsibility than is true of larger groups.[8] But it should also be recognized that students who are abroad for the first time often feel the need to travel in larger groups until they are secure enough about their ability to negotiate their way in foreign places. Only when they have had the time to develop a few close relationships will they feel comfortable traveling and spending a lot of time with one or two people. In any case, whatever the size of the group, there is no doubt that independent travel in a foreign culture is a catalyst for personal growth in students, and should be encouraged. The words of one student speak for many: "Coming to Europe was a huge experience for me, bigger than anything I've ever done before. I'll never be the same because of it."

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[8]Although large groups dilute the educational benefits of travel, it must be said that they do pose other challenges, including the need to cooperate with others and to make joint decisions.